

## Impact on Teacher Education Programs of Students with Intellectual Disabilities Attending College

by Melissa Jones, Cate Weir, and Debra Hart

### INTRODUCTION

The increasing participation of students with intellectual disability (ID) in higher education has significant implications for teacher education programs. As colleges and universities become more diverse and accessible, there will be additional opportunities for teacher education students to become more directly involved with these individuals, thereby enhancing the educational experiences of both pre-service teachers and students with ID.

#### **Context: Why Are More Students with ID Going to College?**

The Higher Education Opportunity Act (HEOA) of 2008 includes provisions specifically for students with ID. These students are now eligible for federal financial aid, including Pell Grants, Supplemental Educational Opportunity Grants, and the Federal Work-Study Program, when attending an eligible transition and postsecondary education program (HEOA, 2008).

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Prior to 2008, students with ID were not eligible for financial aid because, frequently, they do not receive regular high school diplomas, pass General Educational Development equivalency tests, or pass "ability to benefit" tests (Lee, 2009). Thus, the HEOA removed or lessened financial barriers for

many students with ID who are interested in postsecondary education (PSE). This legislation also created funding for 27 Transition and Postsecondary Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability, adding these to the over 200 similar initiatives already existing on college and university campuses nationwide.

These changes to federal legislation, and the proliferation of initiatives to support students with ID in college and university settings, would not have happened without the advocacy efforts of students with ID and their families. Their commitment has paved the way for these students to access PSE options.

#### **Implications for Teacher Education Programs**

Given the growing number of programs and the federally sanctioned opportunities for students with ID in higher education, implications abound for adjusting teacher education curricula to meet this new and exciting demand.

Future teachers need to know:

- That students with ID can go to college alongside their peers without disabilities
- The benefits of students with ID going to college for the student and the institute of higher education (IHE)
- What students with ID need to learn in K-12 to better prepare them for college
- How to include students with ID in the general K-12 curriculum so they are better prepared for college classes
- Dual-enrollment options for 18- to 21-year-old students with ID who are still served by their high-school special-education and transition programs
- Ways to support students with ID, so that they meet with success and remain in college

Teacher education curricula must include information that assists teachers to guide students along a K-12 course of study that will support college participation. Certainly, having knowledge of best practices in PSE for students with ID would be a significant asset for future teachers and promote the establishment of more inclusive PSE for students with ID nationwide.

New opportunities for students with ID to go to college have implications for curricula content and theory, as described above. They also offer rich experiential opportunities for teacher education students through mentoring fellow college students with intellectual disability.

### **Mentoring Partnerships: Pre-service Teachers and Students with Intellectual Disability**

As students with ID pursue a college education, there is a need for both formal and informal resources to support them. Many of the existing college initiatives for students with ID have established resources to address this. For example, education students on many campuses are engaging in supportive relationships with fellow college students with intellectual disability. These students may be referred to as educational coaches, peer mentors, or campus ambassadors. Through these relationships, pre-service teachers experience first-hand the positive effects of high expectations and inclusive educational opportunities for students with intellectual disability.

With a focus on developing meaningful, reciprocal relationships between students with and without disabilities, mentor relationships can benefit all who are involved. Both parties can learn from one another, creating more of an equal partnership than a traditional mentor/mentee relationship. On college campuses where students with intellectual disability are attending classes, opportunities for pre-service teachers to meet and get to know peers with disabilities can be created, and students can apply what they are learning about instructional supports by acting as a tutor or educational coach for a student with ID.

In addition, and perhaps more powerfully, these pre-service

teachers will have the opportunity to form a relationship with a fellow student who has a disability, thereby shaping their perceptions of and expectations for students who experience disability. Research into the development of positive teacher attitudes towards inclusive education suggests that personal experiences, interpersonal contact, and early positive exposure all have a beneficial effect (Campbell, Gilmore, & Cuskelly, 2003; Sharma, Forlin, Loreman, & Earle, 2006; Forlin, 2003; Brownlee & Carrington, 2000). Mentoring relationships between students with and without intellectual disability can offer all of these benefits to pre-service teachers.

### **EXAMPLE 1: Northern Kentucky University Mentor Program**

At Northern Kentucky University, the mentoring program involves pre-service teachers entering into mentor relationships with non-degree-seeking students with ID who are auditing or taking college courses at NKU. Mentoring can include:

- ▶ Attending class, helping to take notes, and encouraging class participation
- ▶ Offering support with studying and completing assignments
- ▶ Helping access email, online resources and assignments
- ▶ Navigating the campus together
- ▶ Assisting with social problem-solving
- ▶ Collaborating with professors
- ▶ Attending campus activities
- ▶ Eating lunch and hanging out together

A service-learning component is also built into the mentorship program at NKU, where students taking a Secondary Special Education course can earn credits by mentoring a college student with ID.

<http://coehs.nku.edu/index.php>

## EXAMPLE 2: Mentors at the College of Charleston REACH Program

At the College of Charleston, college students from all disciplines are invited to participate as mentors. Some students opt to live as housemates of students with intellectual disability in an inclusive residential setting, while others serve as paid residential assistants and provide in-house programming (e.g., fire safety, health and hygiene). Other students provide workshops that align with their own talents (e.g., Introduction to Computing).

Students interested in teaching can enroll as teaching apprentices, and can earn course credit by offering pre-teaching sessions. These sessions help students with ID become familiar with content covered in regular college classes. Other students provide support through the College's Center for Student Learning and Peer Facilitator programs. Finally, social mentors facilitate integration into the full spectrum of college activities, including dances, Greek life, athletic events, and social clubs.

Students who participate in these various roles may be volunteers, may earn course credit, or may receive a stipend. All students receive training and support through the REACH program, and through other campus organizations (e.g., Residence Life, Office of Academic Experience) as well.

<http://reach.cofc.edu/>

## Benefits of Mentoring for Teacher Education Students

A pre-service special-education teacher serving as a mentor said this about the experience:

*This time spent with my mentees has not been just me helping them; it is they helping me as well. I have learned the value of listening instead of speaking... In short, it has made me a better educator and a better person. I can now look at the full picture and see past all the terms and jargon and see the person is really the key to all of this.*

The student's words capture the power that engaging in reciprocal relationships with students with disabilities can have on an emerging teacher:

The mentoring experience "allows me to gain knowledge about the other side of the transition from high school to the 'real world.' I will be working with students to make that transition; it is good to see students that have completed that transition."

While some teacher education students, particularly those studying special education, may have had personal experiences with people with ID already, many have not. Serving as a mentor offers future teachers the opportunity to:

- Practice instructional approaches they are learning in their classes, including accommodating diverse learning styles and needs
- Learn about disability labels from a personal perspective
- Learn about the capacities and gifts that students with significant disabilities possess
- Find out more about social inclusion in a personal and individualized way
- Observe first-hand an innovative approach to transition and young adult educational opportunities for people with disabilities
- Experience young adults with intellectual disability as peers and friends, and not just through the lens of a disability label

From a pedagogical perspective, peer mentoring extends and builds off of classroom learning, adding another valuable field component to the teacher education curriculum. Each

time pre-service teachers are provided with hands-on experiences, these students develop increased competence in their professional field, making connections between the theories and practices taught in the classroom and real-life decision-making, problem solving, and interactions.

Mentoring can be embedded into the teacher education course of study through the integration of service learning opportunities. Students use these experiences to take concepts learned in the classroom and apply them in the community. Students can earn credit toward a final project by logging their mentoring hours and activities, submitting regularly scheduled reflections that address specific questions about their mentoring experiences, and completing a final paper that describes what they have and how the experience will influence their future teaching.

Pre-service teachers who become mentors learn to recognize the value of inclusion, recognizing their future students as people with multiple abilities. Instead of being limited to an ideological stance read or heard about in class, the lessons become real, with meaningful influence on the future professional lives of these promising teachers.

As another pre-service teacher and mentor put it:

*While being a mentor for students with disabilities, I have grown as a person in many ways. I have learned to recognize everyone's strengths and interests; being able to identify someone's interests makes for positive and strong relationships. I have learned the power of faith and believing in one another and the importance of listening to others...I have gained the understanding of pride, patience and hard work.*

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**Including students with ID involves everyone in the campus community. As various departments and offices collaborate to support students with ID, they create a truly inclusive learning community for students with and without disabilities.**

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### **EXAMPLE 3: Peer Mentors at Next Steps at Vanderbilt**

Peer mentors are the backbone of Next Steps at Vanderbilt, as they provide the majority of the support that students with ID receive on campus. A diverse group of individuals from the Vanderbilt University student body are selected to serve as peer mentors, known as “ambassadors.” These students receive training and support from program staff. They may serve as academic tutors and/or job trainers for fellow students with ID. They may also assist with daily planning and attend social events with their mentees.

<http://kc.vanderbilt.edu/site/nextstep/>

### **Meeting the Challenge of Inclusive Postsecondary Education**

Including students with ID involves everyone in the campus community. As various departments and offices collaborate to support students with ID, they create a truly inclusive learning community for students with and without disabilities. Inclusion is not just an approach to K-12 education; it is a societal value that affects all of us, including those in higher education.

The opportunity to work with and learn about college students with ID enhances the educational experience for pre-service teachers, and provides a chance for one-on-one training that was previously unavailable to them. By opening up campuses to individuals who might not otherwise participate in college and supporting them through mentoring and service learning, the campus acts as a microcosm of society and embraces difference as a valued part of their community.

## **EXAMPLE 4: Educational Coaches at Massachusetts Bay Community College**

Educational coaches are key to the full participation of students in the Inclusive Concurrent Enrollment initiatives in Massachusetts. The coaches are either paraprofessionals from partner school districts or individuals hired by the college. They work in conjunction with Disability Services to offer enhanced supports to students. In addition, students learn how to guide their coaches so that their individual needs are met in a manner that they desire.

Coaches assist with travel training to campus, help students participate in activities with peers on campus, and assist students with specific academic goals. Coaches may also help students with community employment. The project coordinator hires, trains, supervises, and coordinates the coaches' activities, in conjunction with the partner school districts.

**[www.thinkcollege.net/for-professionals/](http://www.thinkcollege.net/for-professionals/)**

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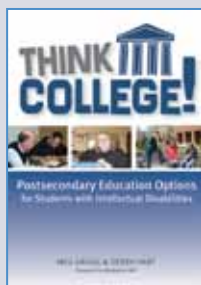
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### **Think College!**

**Postsecondary Education Options for Students  
with Intellectual Disabilities**

**By Meg Grigal, PhD, & Debra Hart, MS**

**Foreword: Madeleine C. Will**

"Tremendous ... will become a milestone in the field filled with both concrete information and materials as well as a vision and plan for the future."

—George Jesien, PhD, Executive Director  
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